

Note: Not all facets in the criterion are required to demonstrate the levels.

MSc Thesis Marking Rubric

Weight: 10%	Thesis Presentation and Structure including language, referencing, data presentation and thesis organisation and flow
90 – 100 (exceptional)	Exceptionally well-written thesis using an appropriate academic style of writing, referencing and excellent flow of argument. Almost faultless and consistent with the presentation and structure found in a good conference paper.
80 – 89 (excellent)	Excellent thesis presentation and academic writing style. <i>The excellent</i> organisation makes the thesis very coherent and easily readable, with additional resources presented in well-formatted appendices. A few grammatical or spelling errors exist. All figures and data presentations are consistent, and graphs are well-presented and easy to interpret. The standard reference style is correctly implemented throughout. With minor corrections, can be submitted to a conference.
70 – 79 (very good)	Very good thesis organisation, ensuring clear flow and argument. Overall, a clear and well-written thesis. Sentences and paragraphs are predominantly well structured. A few grammatical or spelling errors exist. A small number of graphs are not clear or of mediocre quality. Some minor issues with the symbols, nomenclature and/or equations. The standard reference style is correctly implemented. Attention to detail is evident.
60 – 69 (good)	Good thesis structure, easy to follow. The writing style is good and overall readable. Some sentences or paragraphs are difficult to interpret. Some graphs and figures are difficult to understand and/or not very well presented. The reference style is appropriate; however, for many references, full details are not included.
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	The writing is satisfactory but lacks clarity. Some weaknesses in the organisation make it difficult to read. The sentences or paragraphs are often hard to interpret. Many graphs and figures are not well presented, but their message can be understood. Lack of attention to detail (e.g. formatting, quality of figures and units missing). Some references are missing, and reference styles are mixed.
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	Unsatisfactory thesis organisation with missing material or redundancies. Graphs and figures are of a low standard, difficult to understand, and the intention is often unclear. Writing requires substantial improvement . Sentences are not thoughtfully organised into paragraphs with a significant number of grammar/spelling errors. References are missing and incomplete.
30 – 39 (poor)	Poor organisation and structure with obvious missing elements and redundancies. The writing style is unprofessional and/or inappropriate . Poor sentence and paragraph structures make it difficult to read. No attention to detail. Figures and diagrams are messy or taken from other sources, often lacking relevance or meaning. References are mainly omitted and, if used, are very poorly assembled.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	The thesis is unacceptable ; completely disorganised, and it is impossible to understand the work presented. The command of written English is unacceptable and inconsistent. No original figures/data are presented. No or negligible evidence of understanding of a referencing system and digital literacy.

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Weight: 15%	Objectives & Applied Approach/ Methods and MSc Programme's Specific Aspects including determining aims, objectives, approach/methods applied and how well the scope of the project is aligned with the MSc programme specifics (e.g. finance element for EF, innovation, and entrepreneurship for EIE, power perspective for PSE)
90 – 100 (exceptional)	Project aims and objectives are excellent and at the forefront of the state-of-the-art in the discipline, stretching the student's knowledge. The thesis displays an excellent grasp of a range of approaches/methods applicable to the project and in line with advanced scholarly practice and originality in their application. The project has innovation potential.
80 – 89 (excellent)	The project aims and objectives are ambitious , well-defined, and justified by a sound argument, heading towards the state of the art in the discipline. Specific aspects of the particular MSc programme are very well addressed. The thesis displays an excellent grasp of a range of approaches/methods in line with project aims and the current scholarly and engineering practice. The approaches/methods applied demonstrate originality and creativity and are excellently suited to the problem.
70 – 79 (very good)	The project aims and objectives are well-defined and supported by an argument. Specific aspects of the particular MSc programme are very well addressed. The thesis displays a very good grasp of a range of methods and approaches applicable and shows <i>originality</i> in their application.
60 – 69 (good)	Demonstrates good ability to frame the objectives and apply a suitable approach/method. Specific aspects of the particular MSc programme are well addressed. The thesis displays a <i>comprehensive</i> understanding of the methods/approaches applicable to the problem. Shows some <i>originality</i> in their application and a good understanding of how the established approach will achieve the project objectives.
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	The project aims and objectives are clearly defined and in line with the topic. Specific aspects of the particular MSc programme are addressed satisfactorily. Shows a satisfactory understanding of how the selected approach/methods will achieve the objectives; however, the approach applied has <i>some</i> weaknesses.
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	Stated objectives only partially contribute to the project topic. The approaches/methods applied are not fully applicable to the project, and/or have <i>substantial</i> weaknesses.
30 – 39 (poor)	The objectives stated are inconsistent with the project topic. The approaches/methods applied are not appropriate for the objectives stated.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	The project's aims/objectives are not stated . Or the objectives specified are not related to the project topic. The approaches/methods are not stated or specified.

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Weight: 10%	Literature Review & Engineering Practice including literature review, gathering data/evidence and application of the current practices.
90 – 100 (exceptional)	This work meets and often exceeds the standard described in the 80-89 band. In addition, the student can identify gaps in the state of the art of a discipline needing further development and may have innovation potential.
80 – 89 (excellent)	Critically evaluates ¹ , with notable insight , a broad range of literature relevant to the project. Excellent use of evidence/literature to support decision-making and findings throughout the whole thesis. Demonstrate excellent insight into the current research, engineering practice or regulations relevant to the project.
70 – 79 (very good)	Critically evaluates ¹ a range of literature relevant to the project and successfully identifies the key publications to support the undertaken work, evaluation and discussion. Demonstrates a very good understanding of the current research and engineering practice.
60 – 69 (good)	Critically evaluates ¹ a range of literature covering various areas relevant to the project, demonstrating academic honesty. Demonstrates an understanding of implemented theory, methods applied and engineering practices.
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	Critically evaluates ¹ examples of literature covering a satisfactory range of references relevant to the project. Some critiques lack depth, and some examples are more generic. Makes a <i>sound</i> use of appropriate academic/engineering conventions.
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	Reviews <i>only some</i> examples from the literature and <i>is struggling to</i> identify references relevant to the project. Many of the topics relevant to the project are not covered . <i>A lack of discussion and critical evaluation</i> ¹ . References to literature/evidence and the use of academic conventions are insufficient and inconsistent.
30 – 39 (poor)	Fails to identify and/or apply appropriate examples of literature relevant to the project. The use of academic conventions is flawed.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	No or negligible literature review is presented.

¹ Critical evaluation = discussion of contents of referenced documents, with personal opinion and in the context of the project, it is not simply listing the papers or discussing it in general or generic terms.

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Weight: 35%	Quality of Technical Content including knowledge, problem-solving, originality and quality of technical work (e.g. experimental, numerical, design, coding)
90 – 100 (exceptional)	This work meets and often exceeds the standard described in the 80-89 band. The work has innovation potential and is of publishable quality.
80 – 89 (excellent)	Work of excellent standard reflecting in-depth knowledge and understanding. Excellent scope of technical work. Displays mastery of a range of techniques. Excellent engineering judgement when working with information that may be uncertain or incomplete, supported by appropriate reasoning. A student is confident when working with information that may be uncertain or incomplete, giving a correct argument. Demonstrates independence and notable originality in tackling demanding, complex problems. The problem is considered within a wider context as relevant (sustainable, environmental, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics & diversity)
70 – 79 (very good)	Work of a very good scope and standard, reflecting significant knowledge and critical awareness of current problems and/or new insights. Displays a very good grasp of a range of techniques and very good engineering judgment when working with information that may be uncertain or incomplete. Demonstrates self-direction and originality in tackling demanding , complex problems. All stated objectives are met. Understands and assesses a wider context as relevant to the project (sustainable, environmental, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics, D&I)
60 – 69 (good)	Demonstrates systematic knowledge, understanding and critical awareness of the current state of the art. Demonstrates significant scope and a well-defined focus. Displays comprehensive skills in the techniques applied and clearly discusses their limitations. Shows originality in the application of knowledge. Demonstrates self-direction in tackling engineering problems and sound judgment when using information that may be uncertain or incomplete. Nearly all of the stated objectives are met. Demonstrate a good understanding of the wider context in most aspects as relevant to the project (sustainable, environmental, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics, D&I).
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	Demonstrates sound knowledge and understanding of the specialised field with some small gaps. Acceptable scope of technical work. Demonstrates satisfactory engineering skills in applied techniques and understands their limitations. Demonstrates the ability to collect and analyse data and able to use information that may be uncertain or incomplete. Effective in identifying, defining and solving complex problems. Not all objectives are met. Demonstrate a satisfactory understanding of the project's wider context (sustainable, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics & D&I)
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	The scope of work is very limited. Demonstrates some knowledge of the field, but unsatisfactory with substantial weaknesses/gaps . Unsatisfactory ability to define and solve complex problems. Demonstrates some skills in the selected techniques, but with significant weakness in execution. The majority of the objectives are not achieved.
30 – 39 (poor)	Demonstrates substantial weaknesses in the knowledge base, and/or reproduces knowledge without evidence of understanding. Minimal scope of technical work. The work presented does not contribute to the project objectives. Little or no skills were demonstrated in the selected techniques. Inability to define and solve complex problems.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	<i>Fails</i> to demonstrate knowledge of the field. The original technical work is not presented . Inability to recognise the fundamental problems.

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Weight: 30%	Critical Analysis, Discussion and Conclusions including critical analysis of the results, quality assessment, hypothesising and making conclusions
90 – 100 (exceptional)	In addition to the criteria described under the 80-89 band: The analysis and conclusions are of sufficient originality and novelty and likely to receive a similar judgement if submitted to a peer-reviewed journal for independent review.
80 – 89 (excellent)	In addition to the criteria described under the 70-79 band: Shows excellent ability to evaluate methodologies that are critically and robustly supported by evidence and, where appropriate, to propose new hypotheses. The discussion may be suitable for presentation at a national conference. The technical work is subjected to rigorous quality assessment in line with engineering practice. Deals with complex issues systematically and creatively, making excellent judgments. Critically assess and hypothesise on impact within the wider context of the project (sustainable, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics & D&I)
70 – 79 (very good)	The very good critical analysis , strong conclusions supported by evidence and all key points covered. The technical work is subjected to rigorous quality assessment in line with engineering practice. Demonstrates an ability to critically evaluate applied approaches. Deals with complex issues systematically and creatively, making very good judgments. Identifying potential new hypotheses that would require future work. Critically assesses a wider context as relevant to the project (sustainable, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics & D&I)
60 – 69 (good)	Demonstrates confidence in the critical analysis and making sound conclusions supported by evidence, covering most but not all key points. Demonstrates the ability to deal with complex issues both systematically and creatively. Demonstrates the ability to make sound judgments in the absence of complete data. Demonstrated ability to critically discuss a wider context of the project (sustainable, commercial, societal, safety, security, ethics & D&I)
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	Provides evidence of the relevant analysis within the specialised field, with satisfactory critical evaluation of results. Is able to analyse technical issues, make appropriate judgements and draw conclusions that should have some supporting evidence. Demonstrate the consideration of applicable health & safety, diversity, cultural, societal, environmental and commercial matters.
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	Critical analysis and discussion are unsatisfactory . Results/analysis is with some substantial errors and/or inconsistencies that affect the soundness of the argument and/or conclusions. Some conclusions are incorrect or not supported by evidence.
30 – 39 (poor)	Shows little or no critical ability . Poor, inconsistent analysis. Conclusions are incorrect and/or not supported by a valid argument.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	No or negligible critical analysis and discussion <i>conducted</i> . The lack of clear conclusions and/or inconsistent conclusions with the project aims.

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Marks	Overall Assessment
90 – 100 (exceptional)	An exceptional thesis demonstrating in-depth knowledge and understanding of a wider range of subjects. The work and critical analysis are of sufficient novelty/originality and are likely to receive a similar judgment if submitted to a peer-reviewed journal.
80 – 89 (excellent)	Excellent work is subjected to rigorous quality assessment addressing the specific aspects of the MSc programme. Deals with complex issues systematically and creatively, making excellent judgments. The thesis presentation is outstanding and in line with the professional standards and engineering practice, and suitable for presentation at a national conference. Well addressed the wider context of the project and its impact on society. Clear evidence of independent thought and a thorough understanding of the problem.
70 – 79 (very good)	Work of a very good standard, well-rounded, reflecting in-depth knowledge and understanding and excellent critical analysis. The project addresses the specific aspects of the MSc programme. Demonstrates self-direction and originality in tackling <i>demanding</i> problems and suggesting creative solutions that are subjected to rigorous quality assessment in line with engineering practice and understanding the impact on society. The work is suitable for presentation at a student conference.
60 – 69 (good)	Good quality and scope of work are well presented and address specific aspects of the MSc programme. The thesis demonstrates a systematic knowledge, understanding and critical awareness and ability to make sound judgements.
50 – 59 (satisfactory)	Satisfactory thesis and achievements; however, some significant weaknesses/gaps in the key areas/skills are evident. Specific aspects of the MSc programme are addressed satisfactorily. Just satisfies all the learning outcomes.
40 – 49 (unsatisfactory)	Unsatisfactory. A small scope of work is inconsistently presented, demonstrating unsatisfactory knowledge and understanding, with substantial weaknesses/gaps in some key areas evident. Does not satisfy all the learning outcomes.
30 – 39 (poor)	Poor. A small scope of work done and poorly presented. The understanding of the subject is not demonstrated as the objectives and methods selected are not aligned and/or achieved.
0 – 29 (unacceptable)	Very poor. An unacceptable effort.

References:

EC, AHEP (2020). UK Standard for Professional Engineering Competence (UK-SPEC), 2020. United Kingdom: Engineering Council. Retrieved from www.engc.org.uk